in any damage to the temple buildings.' The new plan 'would be executed so quickly that everything would be over by the time people came to realize what was happening.' He also mentioned that the extremists within the temple complex would be given enough time to surrender before army action was initiated. He ruled out any adverse reactions among Sikh jawans serving in the army. According to Alexander, Vaidya's explanation was so convincing that the PM felt the revised plan was the only option left to deal with the situation, and she gave her consent for its implementation as she respected the professional judgement of the generals. [4]

Keeping in mind the deliberations of the two meetings of 25 May and 29 May with General Vaidya, it is crucial to note that just a couple of months earlier, when the SFF-led heliborne operation targeted only at the langar hall rooftop, was being discussed with Nagrani in the presence of Kao, Indira Gandhi had asked pointed questions about the possible casualties involved and had rejected that operation outright, despite relatively modest estimates. Operation Blue Star was a much bigger operation and the main target, the Akal Takht, was heavily fortified with about a hundred fully trained and equipped Sikh extremists. Yet, she approved the operation on the basis of superficial and unchallenged assurances.

A few days before Operation Blue Star was launched, Sardar Swaran Singh was travelling in his personal car from Jalandhar to New Delhi. On the outskirts of Jalandhar he saw a large contingent of army troops on the Grand Trunk Road heading northwards. It was possibly the movement of troops from the Meerut-based 9th Division, which was to reach Amritsar by 30 May. The morning after he reached Delhi, he called Indira Gandhi's special assistant, R.K. Dhawan, and requested an urgent meeting with her, which was fixed for the same afternoon. Drawing her attention to the troop movement, he told the prime minister he was apprehensive that the army was possibly being deployed to clear the Golden Temple of extremists, including Bhindranwale. His advice to her was that she should not under any circumstances let the army enter the Golden Temple, as it could have serious repercussions for Punjab and the country as a whole.